

GROVEFALL

A working concept document for a third-person samurai action-adventure game.

Status: Pre-production concept

Source of truth: The editable portfolio source is docs/grovefall-gdd.md. This PDF mirrors the public document.

Vision

GROVEFALL is a third-person action-adventure concept set in a broken world of mountain villages, ancient shrines, overgrown industry, and an awakening pagoda-shaped machine called the Iron Spire. A small squirrel samurai travels toward the Spire with a katana, a compact energy rifle, and a robotic right arm.

The current work is a gameplay-vision concept. It communicates intended tone and systems; it is not recorded gameplay or a promise of a shipped feature set.

Design pillars

- 1. Precision with momentum.** Movement and combat should feel intentional, readable, and responsive.
- 2. Traversal reveals the world.** Rooftops, ravines, vertical routes, and gliding should make exploration part of the action.
- 3. One connected combat loop.** Katana pressure builds energy for a compact rifle, creating a choice between close-range commitment and a powerful ranged payoff.

Player movement

The concept currently includes sprinting, rooftop leaps, slides, wall jumps, an air dash, and brief gliding across large gaps. These systems are design targets, not implemented features. The camera goal is a readable third-person view that keeps routes and threats visible.

Combat and recharge loop

The hero uses an antique katana and a compact energy rifle. Connected katana hits charge visible rifle cells through the robotic right arm. The charged rifle can then create an opening, stagger a machine, or finish a committed sequence. Dodging is the defensive emphasis. No parry system is established for the concept.

Enemies

Corrupted industrial machines provide distinct shapes, attacks, and weak points. Regular encounters should teach anticipation, spacing, dodges, and opportunities to spend rifle energy. A larger armored machine is the concept's heavy-enemy benchmark: it lands with force, charges, swings broadly, and creates a ground-slam shockwave.

World and Iron Spire

The world combines Japanese timber temples, ruined lantern villages, forest shrines, wet stone, waterfalls, and rusted machinery reclaimed by roots. The Iron Spire appears repeatedly at a distance, then dominates the final reveal. Its upper levels vanish into cloud and its awakening remains an unresolved mystery.

UI and accessibility goals

The video concept avoids invented HUD text. A future playable prototype should prioritize readable contrast, remappable controls, subtitle support, reduced camera-motion options, and visual cues that do not depend only on color. These are goals to validate during prototyping.

Vertical-slice target

The first meaningful prototype target is a compact route through a lantern village: traverse rooftops, glide to a courtyard, confront a small group of machines, charge the rifle through katana hits, spend the charge on a clear target, and leave with the Iron Spire visible in the distance.

Roadmap, risks, and open questions

Near term: document systems, test movement readability, and maintain a transparent trailer/version record.

Next: build one small playable proof of the katana-to-rifle loop and a traversal route.

Risks: scope, animation quality, combat readability, production time, and maintaining character/world consistency across concept material.

Open questions: the Spire's origin, the exact narrative stakes, platform, schedule, enemy roster, progression, and final art-production approach are all TBD.